

I Will Be on Top of the World

The people up top are living a good life while the people at the bottom are fighting to climb up. Parasite is a film that gives insight into how there is a division between the poor and the wealthy in South Korea . The film showed it in 3 major ways: First was how the rich are physically living above the middle and lower classes, and have no idea of the problems they face; second was how those in the lower classes are fighting to get into the upper class; and third is the reoccurring theme about the “smell of the poor”.

Sitting on a high perch, the bird doesn't know the struggles the rabbit goes through when it rains. Early into the film we see that the Kim family is living in a house that is below the floor, this symbolizes how poor they actually are. Then we meet the Park family who live above ground at the top of a hill. This is both a metaphorical and physical representation of how the poor is seen as even less than dirt in Korea, while the rich are like kings of their own castle. We then got to see the disparities between the two families when there was a rainstorm. The film shows the Kim family slowly go from living in luxury, all the way down multiple hills and stairs until they reach their now flooded home. The father grabbed the second place medal that has been hanging on the wall, daughter tried to stop the toilet from flooding and destroying their house even more, while the son was watching the giant rock that was supposed to give them good fortune just float in the water (this showing how their recent good fortune was as fake as the rock). The Kim family lost

everything, so what happened with the Park family during this storm? All they lost due to the rain was the camping trip they planned. The Park family knew nothing of the destruction the storm caused the poor people, and instead they continued on their way like nothing happened at all. We see that the rich don't care for the poor, so surely those in a lower class care for each other, right?

While the rich are able to live their lives freely, the poor are always trying to move up in the world. Because they want to move up in the world, they don't want other people to pass them, so this leads to sabotage. There are two examples of sabotage in the movie, first was when the Kim family got the driver and maid fired, while the second was the blackmail attempts by the former maid and the Kim family. After the son and daughter of the Kim family got a job helping the Park family, the plan was made to get the whole family working under them. To do this, the Kim's planted evidence to get the driver fired by ruining his reputation with the family. I have no doubt that gossip would carry through all of the rich society, so he may never get a job like that again. As for the maid, she exploited her allergies to peaches in order to fake that she had some sort of contagious disease. Because the Park family could no longer trust her to tell the truth, she ended up being fired. Both cases show how the lower classes lose morality if it means they can advance in society. Now the question is once they are in a higher tier of society, can people tell they are from a lower rung?

You might not notice your scent, but other people will. This is a motif that appeared early into the film. The son of the Park family notices the Kim's family smells the same, and we learn later that the smell was the "scent of the poor". This set the idea that there are these almost uncontrollable details that makes the rich know when they are near the lower class. The film uses the smell of the poor in an interesting way to show the Park family is disgusted by the lower classes and can't stand to be near them. This eventually leads to the murder of the father of the Park family by the father of the Kim family. We see that being seen as lesser/disgusting over time after time build up and eventually will explode in an action of rage.

Parasite is a film that gives people the idea of how bad the class disparities are in South Korea. The upper class live so high above the average person that they don't know/care enough to interact with the lower classes. Because being in an upper class is so great, it's probably not a rare dream to see people trying to climb up the societal ladder, but it is equally as common to see people fighting each other to continue up. Even if a person manages to move up in Korean society, people will still know where you came from based on your scent, talking patterns, actions, or any other subjective criteria they can come up with.